

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 101: New Birth and Assurance of Salvation

Part One:

The Meaning and Necessity of the New Birth

The Meaning of the New Birth

The New Birth, also referred to in Scripture as being “born again” or “born from above,” is not a religious metaphor, an emotional experience, or a moral reformation. It is a spiritual event, initiated by God, in which the human spirit previously dead toward God is regenerated by the Holy Spirit and brought into living union with Christ.

Jesus introduced the doctrine of the New Birth with unmistakable clarity in His conversation with Nicodemus. He declared, “*Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God*” (John 3:3). This statement establishes the New Birth not as an optional spiritual upgrade but as an absolute requirement for participation in the life and reign of God. Christ did not say one must be educated, reformed, or religious, but one must reborn.

The phrase translated “born again” carries a double meaning. It signifies both a second birth and a birth from above. This is important, because it shows that salvation is not produced from within fallen humanity but descends from God Himself. The New Birth is therefore not self-generated; it is divinely caused. No person can regenerate themselves, just as no child brings about their own natural birth.

Scripture describes this event as a passing from death to life. Before regeneration, the human spirit exists in a state of separation from God, described by Paul as being “dead in trespasses and sins” (Ephesians 2:1). Death here does not mean non-existence, but alienation: a condition in which the spirit is alive to the world yet unresponsive to God. The New Birth reverses this condition, restoring spiritual life and capacity for communion with God.

Necessity of New Birth

The necessity of the New Birth is rooted in the reality of the Fall. The problem of humanity is not merely ignorance, weakness, or bad habits; it is a corrupted nature. Adam’s sin did not only introduce sinful actions into the human story, it also transmitted a sinful condition. As a result, every person is born into the world physically alive but spiritually estranged from God.

This is why moral improvement alone cannot reconcile a person to God. A sinner does not need better behavior first; he needs new life. The gospel does not begin with instruction but with resurrection. **Until spiritual life is imparted, even the most sincere religious efforts remain disconnected from God’s saving work.**

Jesus made this clear when He said, *“That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit”* (John 3:6). Flesh cannot produce spirit. Human effort cannot generate divine life. Only the Spirit of God can awaken the human spirit and bring it into fellowship with God.

The New Birth, therefore, is not about joining a church, adopting Christian ethics, or accepting doctrinal facts. It is about a change of nature, not merely a change of direction. Without this inward transformation, no external conformity has saving power.

Regeneration is fundamentally the work of God. Scripture is careful to place salvation’s origin not in human willpower but in divine mercy. John writes that believers are those who were born, *“not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God”* (John 1:13).

This does not deny human responsibility to repent and believe, but it clarifies the order of salvation. Faith does not cause the New Birth in the sense of human merit; rather, **faith is the means by which the regenerating work of God is received.** Salvation is entirely of grace, from beginning to end.

The Holy Spirit is the agent of regeneration. He convicts the heart of sin, reveals Christ, and imparts new life. This work is mysterious yet real, invisible yet transformative. Jesus compared it to the wind, that is, its origin unseen, its effects undeniable. Where the Spirit regenerates, there is life.

Part Two: Repentance, Faith, and the Nature of Regeneration

Repentance and Faith in the Experience of the New Birth

Although regeneration is the sovereign work of God, Scripture consistently presents repentance and faith as the human response through which the New Birth is received. These two are not separate stages of salvation but inseparable aspects of turning to God. **Repentance concerns a change of heart and direction**, while **faith concerns trust and reliance upon Christ**. Together, they form the doorway through which divine life enters the human spirit.

Repentance, in biblical terms, goes far beyond sorrow for sin or fear of judgment. It is a profound inward turning: a reorientation of the heart away from self-rule and toward God's authority. When the Spirit convicts a person, He exposes not only sinful actions but the deeper rebellion of the heart. **True repentance acknowledges God's rightness and one's own need for mercy. It does not negotiate terms with God; it yields.**

Faith, on the other hand, is not mere agreement with gospel facts. It is personal trust in the person and work of Jesus Christ. Saving faith rests entirely upon Christ's finished work: His death, burial, and resurrection as sufficient for reconciliation with God. Faith does not look inward for worthiness but outward to Christ for righteousness.

The New Birth occurs where repentance and faith meet divine grace. When a person turns from sin and self and places trust in Christ, the Holy Spirit regenerates the human spirit. This regeneration is not a gradual moral improvement **but an immediate impartation of life**. At that moment, the believer is united with Christ, forgiven, justified, and made alive unto God.

What Happens in Regeneration

Regeneration affects the deepest core of the human person: the spirit. Scripture teaches that prior to salvation, the spirit of man is separated from God. At the New Birth, this separation is removed, and spiritual life is imparted. Paul describes this as being *"made alive together with Christ"* (Ephesians 2:5).

This impartation of life includes several realities:

First, there is a new relationship with God. The believer is no longer a stranger or enemy but a child. Adoption accompanies regeneration, granting the believer access, intimacy, and inheritance in Christ. God is no longer merely known about; He is known personally.

Second, there is a new nature. While the believer still lives in a fallen world and contends with the flesh, the ruling principle of life has changed. The regenerated spirit now has an inclination toward God. There is a new capacity for obedience, worship, and love for righteousness. This does not mean sinlessness, but it does mean a

decisive break from sin's dominion.

Third, there is an inward witness of life. Regeneration produces spiritual sensitivity. The Word of God becomes living and active rather than distant or dull. Prayer becomes relational rather than mechanical. The believer begins to sense conviction, guidance, and fellowship with God in a way that was previously absent.

This inward transformation is why Scripture insists that salvation cannot be reduced to external conformity. Without regeneration, religious practice remains hollow. With regeneration, even imperfect obedience flows from living union with Christ.

The Evidences of the New Birth

While the New Birth itself is invisible, its effects are observable. Scripture never teaches believers to base assurance solely on emotions or experiences; instead, it points to evidences that flow from regeneration.

One primary evidence is a changed relationship with sin. The regenerated person may still stumble, but sin no longer reigns comfortably. There is conviction where once there was indifference. There is grief where once there was pleasure. This inner resistance to sin is not self-produced; it is the result of new life within.

Another evidence is love for God and His people. John writes that love for the brethren is a mark of having passed from death to life. Regeneration produces a supernatural affection for God's family, even across differences of background and personality. This love is not sentimental but rooted in shared life in Christ.

A third evidence is perseverance in faith. Genuine regeneration produces endurance. While believers may struggle, question, or experience seasons of dryness, they do not ultimately abandon Christ. This perseverance is not sustained by human strength alone but by God's preserving grace at work within the believer.

Finally, there is a growing conformity to Christ. Regeneration initiates a process: sanctification, that is, by which the believer is progressively transformed. The New Birth does not complete this work, but it makes it inevitable. Where life exists, growth follows.

Part Three: **Assurance of Salvation: Its Nature, Foundation, and Balance**

The Meaning of Assurance of Salvation

Assurance of salvation refers to the settled confidence that a believer has concerning their standing with God in Christ. It is not arrogance, presumption, or emotional excitement; it is a quiet, grounded certainty rooted in God's work and God's Word. Assurance answers the question, "How do I know that I am truly saved?"

Scripture presents assurance not as a special privilege for advanced believers but as a normal aspect of Christian life. The apostle John states clearly, "*These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life*" (1 John 5:13). The word "Knowing" is not merely hoping, it is a language of the New Testament.

However, assurance must be rightly understood. It does not mean the absence of temptation, doubt, or struggle. Even mature believers may face seasons of spiritual dryness or inner questioning. **Assurance is not the denial of struggle; it is confidence in Christ despite struggle.**

The Foundation of True Assurance

True assurance rests on three interrelated foundations: the objective work of Christ, the testimony of Scripture, and the witness of the Holy Spirit.

First, assurance is grounded in the finished work of Christ. Salvation does not rest upon the believer's performance but upon Christ's obedience, sacrifice, and resurrection. If assurance depended on human consistency, it would always fluctuate. But because it rests on Christ's completed work, it can remain firm even when the believer feels weak. The cross is not an emotional experience; it is a historical and eternal accomplishment.

Second, assurance is anchored in the promises of Scripture. God's Word declares what God has done for those who believe. Verses such as John 5:24, Romans 8:1, and Ephesians 2:8–9 provide objective statements of salvation that stand regardless of emotional condition. Mature assurance learns to trust what God has said over what the heart may feel.

Third, assurance is confirmed by the witness of the Holy Spirit. Paul writes that the Spirit bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God. This witness is not always dramatic; often it is a quiet inward knowing: a sense of belonging, a cry of "Abba, Father" rising from within. This inward testimony complements, but never replaces, the authority of Scripture.

When these three work together: Christ's work, God's Word, and the Spirit's witness,

assurance becomes both stable and alive.

Assurance & Presumption

One of the great dangers in teaching assurance is sliding into presumption. Presumption claims peace without repentance, security without submission, and salvation without transformation. Scripture never supports such confidence.

Presumption often reveals itself in a careless attitude toward sin. Where there is no grief over sin, no desire for holiness, and no hunger for God, assurance must be questioned. **The New Testament consistently connects assurance with abiding in Christ, walking in the light, and continuing in faith.**

Assurance, by contrast, produces humility, gratitude, and obedience. A truly assured believer does not say, “I am safe, therefore my life does not matter.” Rather, they say, “Because I am saved by grace, I desire to please the One who saved me.” **Assurance strengthens holiness; it does not weaken it.**

The absence of struggle is not evidence of salvation; often, struggle itself is evidence of spiritual life. *Dead things do not wrestle.*

The Security of Salvation in Christ

Scripture teaches that salvation is secure because it is God’s work from beginning to end. Jesus declared that no one can pluck His sheep out of His hand. Paul affirmed that nothing can separate believers from the love of God in Christ Jesus. These assurances point not to human grip on God but to God’s grip on the believer.

This safety does not negate human responsibility. Believers are called to abide, persevere, and continue in faith. **Yet even this perseverance is sustained by grace.** God does not save and abandon; He saves and preserves.

Security in Christ provides freedom from fear, not license for sin. Where fear dominates, love cannot mature. Assurance frees the believer to grow, serve, and endure trials without the constant anxiety of rejection by God.

Balance

Scripture encourages self-examination, but not self-condemnation. Believers are instructed to examine whether they are in the faith, yet this examination is meant to lead to clarity, repentance if necessary, and renewed trust in Christ; not endless introspection.

Doubt may arise from various sources: immature understanding, unresolved sin, spiritual attacks, or emotional instability. The remedy is not despair but returning to the foundations: Christ’s work, God’s Word, and the Spirit’s witness.

A healthy believer learns to distinguish between conviction and condemnation. Conviction draws the heart back to God; condemnation drives it away. “*There is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.*” Romans 8:1

Concluding Summary

The New Birth is the sovereign work of God by which spiritual life is imparted to the human spirit through repentance and faith in Christ. It results in a new nature, a new relationship with God, and a transformed direction of life. Assurance of salvation is the believer's settled confidence in this saving work, grounded not in personal perfection but in Christ's finished work, confirmed by Scripture, and witnessed by the Holy Spirit.

Together, the New Birth and assurance of salvation form the foundation of Christian life. Without the New Birth, there is no spiritual life. Without assurance, spiritual growth is crippled by fear. When both are rightly understood, the believer stands firm: humble, secure, and ready to grow into maturity.

Signed:

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